

Chapter 2

But I Love Everything

If you've listened to our podcast for any amount of time, you know how much I (Jill) love my nieces and nephews. I live far from them, so visiting is one of my deepest joys. We have so. much. fun. Mostly because I don't need to worry about sleep schedules, nutritional content of food, or anything related to behavior modification. We go on walks, skip rocks, pick flowers, eat snacks, and play "taco"—a game we made up where I try to catch them and roll them in a blanket like a taco. It's wild. And hilarious. And someone always gets hurt (usually me). In the midst of all these shenanigans, something that continues to strike me about these kiddos is their unrelenting curiosity. It shows up in each one of them a bit differently, but they are all so genuinely curious about the world around them.

For Jack, my four-year-old nephew, curiosity showed up through his fascination with slugs. As it turns out, the backyard was full of them, and he was on a mission to collect them all. He had no reservations about picking them up, and we quickly learned that the slime of slugs is nearly impossible to get off skin, but that didn't deter him. He was so intrigued by those little mollusks, and with every newfound slug there were newly formed questions: "What's that one doing? Why is he so small? Is this his home? Where's his mom? Can we go look for more, Aunt Jill?" I had no answers to his questions except for that last one: "Jack, do you think we could just look at the snails you already found?" "But I love them ALL!" he pleaded. Truthfully, I understood. I want all the good things too. Maybe not snails, but there's a lot of cool stuff I love and want. Like dinners out, multiple